

No ceasefire: On the Russia-Ukraine war

Russia is utilising the **deepening chasm** among Ukraine's **key allies**

Ukrainian and Russian officials met up in Istanbul, Türkiye, last week, their first direct meeting since March 2022, the year when Russia **invaded** Ukraine. Little was achieved except for one agreement on **swapping** 1,000 prisoners of war each. The Ukrainian **delegation** rightfully complained that Moscow had made "new and unacceptable demands". Russia's **posturing**, however, **seems** to be a consequence of the **dithering** by Kyiv's key ally, the U.S. **In the run-up to** the meeting, **Kyiv**, which has **been on the back foot** in the conflict, losing **substantial** territory in the east and **reeling under** failures such as the **retreat** from the Kursk offensive, **had** sought a 30-day ceasefire — an outcome that the U.S. was also pushing. While the U.S. has been **discernibly** less enthusiastic about continuing to **arm** and support the Ukrainians, during Donald Trump's second term in the White House, Kyiv's European allies had **urged** Moscow to agree to the ceasefire, or face increased **sanctions** and the transfer of weapons to Ukraine. After pushing Kyiv to the meeting without the ceasefire as a **precondition**, Mr. Trump had said **on the eve of** the Istanbul meet that it would not **yield** anything until he met directly with Russian President Vladimir Putin. True to his **mercurial** nature, he went on to say that the **conditions** of a peace deal — which he has been pushing as a **means** for the U.S. to exit the conflict — **could** only be **negotiated** between Russia and Ukraine, with possible help from the **Pope**.

Amid this diplomatic uncertainty from Washington, the Russians have shown no **inclination to back down** from their **maximalist** demands on rejecting security guarantees for Ukraine **in the event of a truce**, and for its **demilitarisation**. This week, Russia continued to launch a **barrage** of attacks. Kyiv did **manage to rally** its European allies to support it militarily while **imposing** fresh sanctions on Russia. But the Ukrainian regime's **precarity** in its eastern regions **is evident** with Russia continuing to hold on to significant territory and **gaining ground** in fresh **incursions** from the east. With Mr. Trump showing **scant regard** towards taking a consistent position, and seemingly **staking out** a line that is different from that of the Europeans, Kyiv might be left with a **Hobson's choice** — **accommodate** some of Russia's territorial demands to begin the process of peace or **endure** the **attritional war** with limited support. Mr. Putin might have **seized** the **upper hand** in the geopolitical **dynamics** of the war, but its effects have been devastating for Moscow as well. Reason suggests that peace would yield greater **dividends** than continuing an illegal **invasion** and this should allow for a fresh **impetus** for talks **leading to a ceasefire. The ball is in the Kremlin's court.** **[Practice Exercise]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Ceasefire** (noun) – truce, armistice, suspension, stoppage, halt युद्धविराम
trouble, under pressure पिछड़ जाना / रक्षात्मक स्थिति में होना
2. **Deepening** (adjective) – intensifying, worsening, escalating, growing, expanding गहराता हुआ
3. **Chasm** (noun) – gap, divide, rift, split, gulf गहरी दरार
4. **Key** (adjective) – crucial, vital, essential, important, strategic मुख्य
5. **Ally** (noun) – partner, supporter, friend, associate, confederate सहयोगी
6. **Invade** (verb) – attack, assault, overrun, raid, intrude आक्रमण करना
7. **Swap** (verb) – exchange, trade, switch, barter, substitute अदला-बदली करना
8. **Delegation** (noun) – team, group, representatives, mission, committee प्रतिनिधिमंडल
9. **Posturing** (noun) – stance, attitude, pose, bluff, display दिखावा
10. **Dithering** (noun) – hesitation, indecision, wavering, vacillation, delay हिचकिचाहट
11. **In the run-up to** (phrase) – preceding, before, prior to, in advance of, leading up to से पहले की अवधि
12. **Be on the back foot** (phrase) – be defensive, disadvantaged, losing ground, in
13. **Substantial** (adjective) – considerable, significant, large, meaningful, massive महत्वपूर्ण
14. **Reel under** (phrasal verb) – suffer, struggle, collapse, stagger, be overwhelmed झेलना
15. **Retreat** (noun) – withdrawal, fallback, pullback, recoil, evacuation पीछे हटना
16. **Discernibly** (adverb) – noticeably, clearly, visibly, detectably, evidently स्पष्ट रूप से
17. **Arm** (verb) – equip, supply, furnish, provide, gear up हथियार देना
18. **Urge** (verb) – encourage, press, request, advocate, exhort आग्रह करना
19. **Sanction** (noun) – penalty, punishment, restriction, embargo, deterrent प्रतिबंध
20. **Precondition** (noun) – requirement, prerequisite, term, stipulation, obligation पूर्व शर्त
21. **On the eve of** (phrase) – just before, prior to, ahead of, on the night before, in anticipation of की पूर्व संध्या पर
22. **Yield** (verb) – produce, give in, result in, generate, concede परिणाम देना

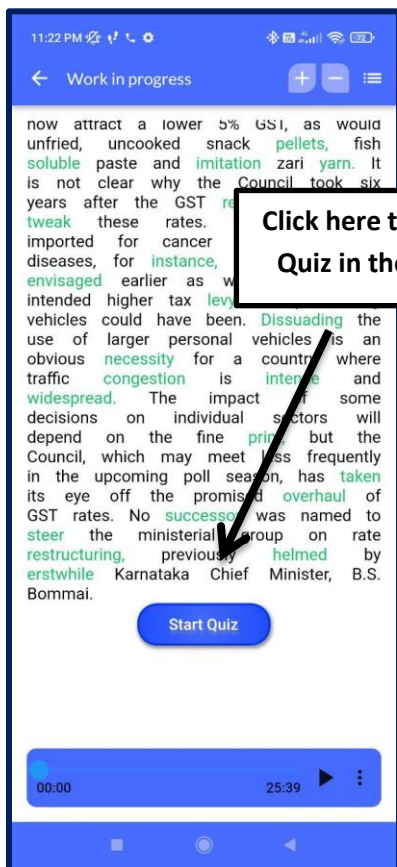
23. **Mercurial** (adjective) – unpredictable, volatile, fickle, temperamental, erratic
चंचल / अस्थिर
24. **Means** (noun) – method, way, process, mechanism, mode साधन
25. **Negotiate** (verb) – discuss, bargain, settle, mediate, consult बातचीत करना
26. **Pope** (noun) – pontiff, head of the Catholic Church, spiritual leader पोप (कैथोलिक धर्मगुरु)
27. **Amid** (preposition) – among, during, in the middle of, amidst, surrounded by के बीच
28. **Inclination** (noun) – tendency, preference, leaning, desire, disposition झुकाव
29. **Back down** (phrasal verb) – retreat, concede, withdraw, yield, surrender पीछे हटना
30. **Maximalist** (adjective) – uncompromising, extreme, rigid, hardline, non-negotiable अधिकतम की मांग करने वाला
31. **In the event of** (phrase) – in case of, if, should it happen that, upon, during की स्थिति में
32. **Truce** (noun) – ceasefire, peace, armistice, agreement, pause अस्थायी युद्धविराम
33. **Demilitarisation** (noun) – disarmament, removal of military force, pacification सैन्य विहीनकरण
34. **Barrage** (noun) – volley, attack, onslaught, bombardment, hail भारी बमबारी
35. **Manage** (to) (verb) – succeed, achieve, accomplish, pull off, cope सफल होना
36. **Rally** (verb) – unite, gather, come together, mobilize, regroup समर्थन जुटाना
37. **Impose** (verb) – enforce, apply, levy, inflict, institute थोपना
38. **Precarity** (noun) – insecurity, instability, uncertainty, danger, fragility अस्थिरता / संकट
39. **Evident** (adjective) – obvious, clear, apparent, visible, noticeable स्पष्ट
40. **Gain ground** (phrase) – advance, progress, make headway, move forward, succeed बढ़त हासिल करना
41. **Incursion** (noun) – invasion, intrusion, raid, attack, penetration आक्रमण / घुसपैठ
42. **Scant** (adjective) – minimal, limited, meagre, insufficient, sparse बहुत कम
43. **Regard** (noun) – consideration, respect, attention, concern, esteem ध्यान

44. **Stake out** (phrasal verb) – claim, declare, assert, mark, identify स्थिति तय करना / दावा करना
45. **A Hobson's choice** (phrase) – no real choice, take it or leave it, forced option मजबूरी में लिया गया विकल्प
46. **Accommodate** (verb) – adjust, adapt, compromise, reconcile, yield समायोजन करना
47. **Endure** (verb) – suffer, tolerate, withstand, persevere, survive सहन करना
48. **Attritional war** (noun) – exhausting war, draining conflict, prolonged battle, wearing down war थकाने वाला युद्ध
49. **Seize** (verb) – capture, grab, take over, snatch, occupy कब्जा करना
50. **Upper hand** (noun) – advantage, dominance, control, superiority, lead बढ़त / प्रभुत्व
51. **Dynamic** (noun) – interaction, force, drive, process, flow गति / परस्पर क्रिया
52. **Dividend** (noun) – benefit, return, profit, reward, payoff लाभ
53. **Invasion** (noun) – attack, incursion, assault, offensive, raid आक्रमण
54. **Impetus** (noun) – boost, stimulus, push, momentum, drive प्रोत्साहन
55. **Lead** (to) (verb) – result in, cause, bring about, direct, produce वजह बनना
56. **The ball is in someone's court** (phrase) – it's someone's responsibility, it's up to them, their move, their decision अब जिम्मेदारी उसकी है

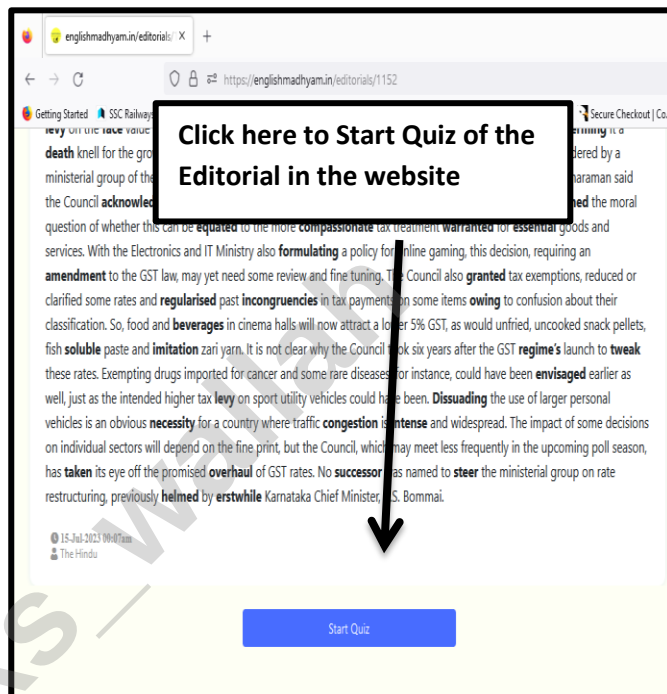
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Historic Meeting:** Ukrainian and Russian officials held direct talks in Istanbul for the first time since March 2022.
2. **Limited Outcome:** The only agreement reached was a mutual swap of 1,000 prisoners of war.
3. **Unacceptable Demands:** Ukraine accused Russia of presenting new and unacceptable conditions during the talks.
4. **US Dithering:** Russia's hardened stance is partly attributed to the lack of clear and consistent support from the United States.
5. **Kyiv's Weak Position:** Ukraine is currently on the defensive, having lost significant territory in the east and failing in key offensives.
6. **Push for Ceasefire:** Ukraine and the U.S. had both sought a 30-day ceasefire before the Istanbul meeting, but it was not secured.
7. **European Allies' Efforts:** European nations pressured Moscow for a ceasefire by threatening more sanctions and weapons transfers.
8. **Trump's Role:** Donald Trump, likely returning to the presidency, dismissed the meeting's prospects and insisted any peace deal must involve direct talks between him and Putin.
9. **Trump's Inconsistency:** He has offered mixed messages, at times pushing for peace but also sidelining European allies' efforts.
10. **Russian Intransigence:** Russia continues to demand Ukraine's demilitarisation and refuses any security guarantees for Ukraine.
11. **Continued Attacks:** Russia has maintained aggressive military action, launching new attacks while holding key territories.
12. **European Military Support:** Despite U.S. wavering, European allies continue to back Ukraine with military aid and new sanctions on Russia.
13. **Precarious Ukrainian Position:** Ukraine remains vulnerable in the east, with Russia making fresh gains.
14. **Hobson's Choice for Kyiv:** Ukraine may be forced to choose between conceding territory or enduring a prolonged war with diminishing support.
15. **Call for Peace:** The editorial concludes that while Putin holds a stronger geopolitical hand, a ceasefire and peace talks would benefit all — and it's now Russia's move.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



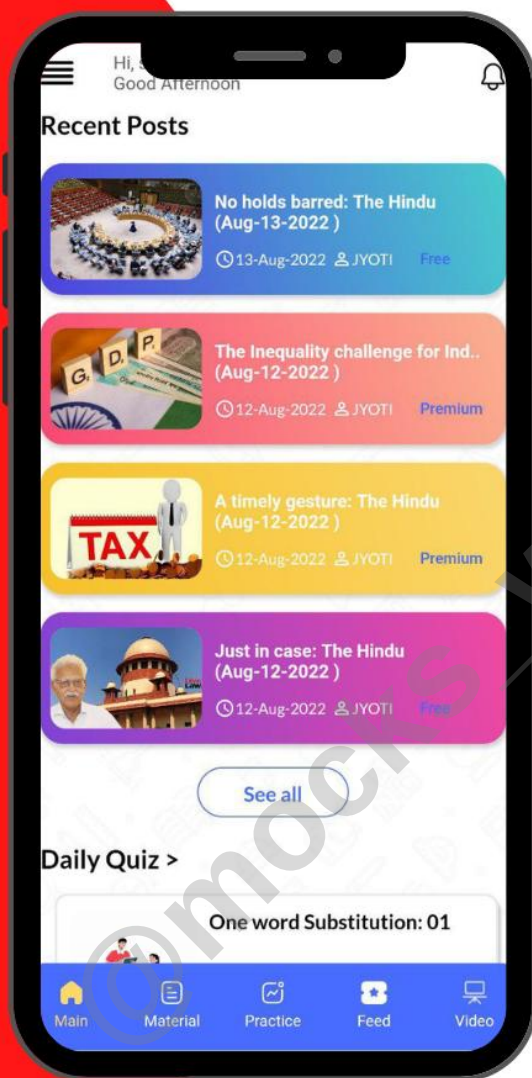
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